

WHAT PRICE RICE



On Annadurai's birth centennial, the Dravidian parties take competitive populism to new heights

By S. Senthil Kumar

Recent history shows that elections eve sops have seldom bettered the quality of life of the ordinary citizens. On the contrary, they remain a drain on the exchequer. But political parties nevertheless continue to indulge in competitive populism in the belief that it is the best bet to retain power.

With less than a year left for the Lok Sabha elections, the ruling DMK has scaled new heights in populism, offering rice at Re 1 per kg in the Public Distribution System for families living below the poverty line. It was no coincidence that Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi made this announcement last week at the birth centenary celebrations of the DMK founder C.N. Annadurai.

Long before N.T. Rama Rao ousted the Congress and rode to power with the promise to provide rice at Rs 2 per kg to families below the poverty line in Andhra Pradesh, it was Annadurai who discovered the merits of populist policies when in the 1967 assembly elections, he adopted "Rice at Re 1" a paddy (equal to 1.5 kg) as the DMK's main plank. The Congress lost and has remained out of power since then, but in the years that followed, the DMK and its splinter group, the AIADMK, have taken competitive populism one notch up. So much so, that the denizens of the state

actually look forward to elections for the freebies that come their way. Karunanidhi's largesse which also includes subsidised cooking ingredients is expected to set the exchequer back by more than Rs 500 crore annually, but no one, barring the state's planners, is complaining.

If the DMK is doling out goodies, can the rival AIADMK be far behind? After the state Government's initiatives in rice populism, the heat is clearly on the AIADMK. The diva of Poes Garden Jayalalithaa was forced to scale up her own party's celebrations of the Anna centennial. Ever since she took over the reins of the party, her political mentor and the party founder, the late M.G. Ramachandran, has paled into in-

significance. But the AIADMK was forced to fall back on his popularity, which still remains intact, after the film star-turned-DMK founder Vijaykanth staked claims of being MGR's political heir. Apprehensive of the new entrant from Kodambakkam walking off with the MGR vote bank, which hitherto was the AIADMK's, Jayalalithaa has now resurrected her hero of scores of films even as she seeks to appropriate Annadurai's legacy.

In the last assembly elections in 2006, both the DMK and the AIADMK liberally offered sops without a care about who would foot the bill and how. While Karunanidhi offered free colour television sets and rice at Rs 2 per kg, Jayalalithaa's offer to distribute free computers looked less attractive to the ordinary voter, which perhaps explains why AIADMK had to suffer defeat in a closed-fought contest. Now with the general elections due early next year, the sop opera has intensified and the DMK has also announced upgradation of the primary health centres and free nutritious food for pregnant women on the Anna centenary. While these schemes have been widely welcomed, the Government's decision to release 1,405 convicts serving life-terms has landed the ruling party in controversy.

The latest sop is considered to be an attempt to divert public attention from the poor administration and to

ALL FOR ONE: A woman with rice bag at the inauguration of the cheap rice scheme

